

The CIO's Chief Concerns About the Cloud



How true is the statement that a business can go to market faster using cloud services?



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The cloud essentially refers to on-demand access to a shared pool of computing resources or services that can be rapidly provisioned and released. The characteristics of the cloud improve a business' agility by providing features including dynamic configuration of IT resources, a quick response to business demands and self-service provisioning. This enables a business to respond to new requirements much more quickly and go to market faster.

What should one look for in a cloud computing vendor?

For any IT organisation looking to transition to virtualisation and cloud computing, selecting an operating system and cloud computing vendor should come down to a few key considerations. These include: (1) avoiding vendor lock-in so as to achieve maximum flexibility over the long term; (2) the cloud solution must be able to support hybrid cloud infrastructure with support for multiple virtualisation technologies like Xen, KVM, Hyper-V and VMware; and (3) the operating environment must support easy, on-demand scalability.



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Cloud computing fundamentally changes the way in which IT services are delivered. Instead of both owning and managing IT services for themselves, or using an outsourcing approach built around dedicated hardware, software, and support services, organisations can opt for cloud computing to meet their IT requirements using a flexible, on-demand and rapidly scalable model that requires neither ownership on their part, nor provision of dedicated resources.

Before deploying a cloud service, it is important for the organisation to take a close look at its existing IT security processes, practices and technologies. It is important to learn as much as possible about the cloud service provider's security, with the goal of trying to identify (and secure against) variations between the two. Organisations deploying cloud-based architecture should find out how the cloud service provider segregates and isolates multiple tenants — where exactly will the data reside, who will monitor the data, etc. They should ask the cloud provider for the results of recent security tests or audits it has performed w.r.t its own infrastructure, and clearly understand what the service provider's responsibilities and guarantees are as described in its service level agreement.



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Today, cloud computing is perceived as a great leveller among businesses, and it is allowing both large and small/medium businesses to grow faster. Many applications are now written specifically for the cloud, a trend that enterprises will need to accept to keep pace with the competitive environment. A cloud deployment reduces the capital expenditure required from SMBs and larger companies alike, with the added benefit of allowing businesses to be able to use the latest cutting-edge technology.

Before setting out to choose a cloud computing vendor, it's important to analyse your choices at three different levels. The first is product; will it help you better meet business goals? The second is the service provider; is the provider a stable company with lots of other customers? And the third is the transition; do you understand what is involved, such as the possible interruptions to business during the transition? Once these aspects are clear, it's important to choose the right vendor who can provide efficient and easy-to-use service, and is also able to manage your workloads better.